M365-07 · Teams Provisioning, Naming & Lifecycle

When a Team is the right object and when it is not, what creating one actually creates, and how one stops being somebody's problem when its owner leaves.

Field	Value
Document ID	M365-07
Version	1.0 · Known Good edition, by Kevin Zelman
Catalogue domain	A. Microsoft 365
Operating tier	Tier 2 — Advanced Technical Services renames, reassigns ownership and archives. Tier 1 answers the §2 "which object do I need?" question in the conversation. Tier 3 owns the creation, naming and expiration configuration in §10.
Review cycle	Annually.
Relationship to M365-10	Every Team creates a SharePoint site. That site is governed by M365-10 — owner, classification, stated purpose, review, closure — and this document does not restate any of it. Where the two appear to disagree, §6 resolves it explicitly rather than leaving the reader to choose.
Relationship to M365-04	A Team and a Microsoft 365 group are the same underlying object. A dynamic-membership Team is a dynamic group, and it consumes the same finite directory attributes M365-04 §7 registers. These two documents must not contradict each other, and §4 and §7 are written against M365-04 deliberately.

1. Purpose

Creating a Team takes about fifteen seconds and creates six things: a Microsoft 365 group, a group mailbox, a shared calendar, a SharePoint site, a set of channels with folders behind them, and a permanent obligation on somebody to look after all of it. The person creating it is aware of one of those six.

That asymmetry is the whole of the problem. The organization does not have a Teams problem in the sense of too much chat; it has an object-choice problem and an ownership problem. People create a Team when they wanted a channel, a site when they wanted a Team, and a group chat when they needed something that would still exist in March. Then the person who created it changes role, and what is left is a Team with content in it, no owner, and no way to tell whether it matters.

The architecture behind this has been explained repeatedly and well — by email, in long threads, to whoever asked. Explained by email it cannot be cited, cannot be found by the next person, and has to be written again. This document is that explanation, published once.

2. Team, channel, site or chat — the decision people actually get wrong

This is the centre of the document. Almost every problem later in it is caused by getting this wrong at the start, and the choice is genuinely not obvious.

Use	When	What it actually creates	Watch out for
A group chat	A conversation between a handful of people about something that will be finished this month.	Nothing durable. Files shared in it live in the SENDER'S OneDrive, not anywhere shared.	It has no owner and no membership record. When somebody leaves, their files in the chat go with their OneDrive (M365-16 §5). Never the home for anything institutional.
A channel in an EXISTING Team	A new workstream belonging to a group of people who already work together.	A folder in that Team's existing site. No new group, no new site, no new owner.	Nothing much. This is the answer far more often than people think, and it is the cheapest one by a wide margin.
A new Team	A standing group of people with an ongoing shared purpose — a department, a committee, a project with a defined membership.	A Microsoft 365 group, a group mailbox and calendar, a SharePoint site, and an ownership obligation.	Every Team is also a mail-addressable group (M365-04 §3) and a site (M365-10). Creating one to hold three documents is expensive in governance terms and free in cash terms, which is exactly the wrong incentive.
A SharePoint site with no Team	A document library or an intranet page that many people read and few people discuss — policies, forms, a departmental resource area.	A site, under M365-10.	If the group needs to talk about the content, they will end up in a chat about it anyway. Consider whether the honest answer is a Team.
A shared mailbox	People outside the organization need to reach a function, not a person.	A mailbox with an address and members (M365-03).	A Team does not give you a public address people can write to. These solve different problems and are frequently confused.
A distribution list or dynamic group	You need to send mail to a set of people. Nothing more.	A group object with no site and no chat (M365-04).	Do not create a Team to reach people by email. That is the most common over-build there is.

> **The two questions that resolve almost every case**
>
> FIRST: do these people already work together somewhere? If yes, the answer is a channel in that Team, not a new Team. A department with eleven Teams has one Team and ten channels, and it acquired the other ten one reasonable decision at a time.
>
> SECOND: will this still need to exist in a year, and can you name the person who will look after it? If you cannot name that person, you do not need a Team — you need a chat, or you need to ask the department that does own the work.

3. Self-service creation: kept on, with three conditions

The obvious response to team sprawl is to switch off self-service creation and put an approval queue in front of it. The organization should not do that, and it is worth being precise about why.

The argument for an approval queue	Why it usually fails
It stops Teams being created that should not exist.	It does not. It defers them. Every request still arrives, and now it arrives in a queue that has to be staffed by a department that, in most small organizations, is understaffed and whose staff wear several hats. The sprawl becomes a backlog, which is the same problem with a worse response time and an SLA attached to it.
It puts a human check on naming and classification.	A naming policy and a required classification do that at creation, automatically, with nobody in the loop. A human check does the same job more slowly and less consistently.
It gives IT visibility.	A monthly report gives IT better visibility than an approval queue does, because it also catches what was created before the queue existed and what has since gone wrong.
It signals that Teams are not free.	This is the one real argument, and §2 makes the point better than a wait does. A queue teaches people to route around IT, not to think harder.

So self-service creation stays on for staff. It is conditioned on three things, and the conditions are what make it defensible rather than merely convenient.

1. A NAMING STANDARD applied at creation (§4), so that a Team's name says what it is without anyone having to open it.
2. A MANDATORY SECOND OWNER (§7). One owner is not an owner; it is a single point of failure with a friendly face, and it is the condition that produces every orphan in §8.
3. AN EXPIRY WITH AN ANNUAL ATTESTATION (§8, ACC-17). Renewal is the action; expiry is the default. This is the only control that removes anything, and without it the other two just produce well-named sprawl.

> **One honest caveat before this is published as a control**
>
> The Microsoft 365 group naming policy and the group expiration policy are both licensed features, counted against the members of the groups they apply to. Tier 3 confirms the organization's entitlement covers the population before §4 and §8 are described to anyone as enforced.
>
> If the entitlement is not there, §4 and §8 are enforced by procedure and by the monthly report instead — which is materially weaker, and the document should say so rather than imply a control that is not switched on.
>
> ACTION: Tier 3 to confirm and report to Tier 4 within 30 days of approval. Recorded against M365-21.

4. Naming

A Team's display name is the group's name, the group mailbox's display name, and the name people see in the address book. It is worth twenty seconds of thought at creation because it is seen thousands of times afterwards.

Kind of Team	Pattern	Notes
Departmental	Dept –	One per department. Additional workstreams are channels (§2).
Committee or governance body	Cmte –	Named for the body, never for its current chair.
Project with an end date	Proj – ()	The year in the name is what makes §8 review possible without asking anyone.
Cross-departmental working group	WG –	Expires by default. Most do not survive their first attestation, which is correct.
Cohort or population	Cohort –	Dynamic membership. Requires a directory attribute, and attributes are finite — read §7 and M365-04 §7 BEFORE promising one.
Synced from a system of record	[deferred]	Teams provisioned from a source of record, such as an HR or business system, are not created by hand. Out of scope until that integration exists; do not create them manually in the meantime.

- The mail nickname follows the M365-04 §4 convention — dept-, grp- — so that the address is predictable even where the display name is not.
- A name describes who is in the Team or what it is for. Never who currently leads it, and never the current name of a project that will be renamed twice.
- Blocked in the naming policy: "test", "temp", "new", a person's name alone, and anything ending in a year that is not a project end date. One consequence worth knowing before you name a Team: renaming it later renames the group, the mailbox display name and the Team as everyone sees it — but it does NOT change the SharePoint site's URL, which keeps the original name permanently. The organization therefore lives with the first name chosen in every link, every bookmark and every document path, long after the visible name has moved on. This is a Microsoft behaviour, not a configuration, and it is the strongest practical argument for §4 existing at all.

5. Channels — standard, private and shared

The three channel types look almost identical in the interface and do entirely different things to permissions and to storage. This is the second most common source of surprise in Teams after §2.

Channel type	Who can see it	Where its files live	Use it for
Standard	Everybody in the Team. Always.	A folder in the Team's own SharePoint site.	The default, and the right answer nearly always. If a conversation needs to exclude Team members, ask why they are in the Team.
Private	Only the channel's members, who must also be members of the Team.	A SEPARATE SharePoint site collection with its own membership and its own owners.	Genuinely sensitive work inside a wider group — a hiring panel inside a departmental Team, a disciplinary matter, a budget under preparation.
Shared	Its members, who may include people from other Teams and, where permitted, other organisations without becoming members of this Team.	A separate site collection again, shared to the participants.	Working with a specific set of people across departmental boundaries, or with an external partner. Governed by M365-14 and ACC-10.

5.1 What to watch

- A private channel cannot be converted to a standard channel, or the other way round. The choice is permanent in practice, and it is made by somebody who has not read this section.
- Each private and shared channel is its own site collection, which means it is its own thing to own, review, classify and search. A Team with nine private channels is ten sites with one visible owner.
- Private-channel sites are easy to miss in an access review and in an eDiscovery scope (M365-16 §8). Whoever scopes a search names them explicitly; they will not be found by searching "the Team".
- A private channel whose owner leaves is orphaned separately from the Team, and the Team's owners cannot see into it to fix it. §8 covers this case specifically because it is the one people do not expect.
- Rule of thumb: if more than about a third of a Team's channels are private, that is not one Team with sensitive corners. That is two Teams, and separating them will make everybody's life simpler.

6. The SharePoint site behind every Team

Every Team has a SharePoint site from the moment it is created, and that site is governed entirely by M365-10 and M365-11. This document deliberately does not repeat those rules — a duplicated rule is a rule that will drift, and the drifted copy will be the one somebody quotes.

For this, read	Which is
Owner, classification and stated purpose	M365-10 §2 — the three things every site has from the moment it exists. They apply to a Team's site from the moment the Team exists.
Who gets access and how it is granted	M365-11 §2 — through the site's groups, never as individual grants.
External sharing on that site	M365-14 §5, with the classification deciding it.
Retention applied to the site	M365-16 §3.

For this, read	Which is
Review and closure of the site	M365-10 §8, which is the same event as §9 of this document.

> **This document and M365-10 §4 appear to contradict each other. They do — and here is the resolution.**
>
> M365-10 §4 step 1 says self-service SITE creation is disabled, which is what allows the owner, classification and purpose to be enforced. Section 3 above says self-service TEAM creation stays on. Both cannot be read literally at the same time, because creating a Team creates a site.
>
> The resolution is that disabling self-service site creation does not disable Team creation, and never did. So the real choice was never "governed sites or ungoverned sites". It was whether the sites that arrive anyway arrive with a Team's naming, ownership and expiry attached, or arrive nameless with one owner and no review date.
>
> THEREFORE: standalone site creation stays disabled and is requested under M365-10. Team creation stays open under §3. A Team-created site enters the M365-10 site register automatically, from the Tier 3 monthly report, rather than through a request form — the register is populated by discovery, not by hope.
>
> ACTION: M365-10 §4 step 1 is amended at its next review to say this in its own words. Raised under GOV-01 §10 as a defect in M365-10, not as an exception in this document.

7. Owners, members and guests

7.1 Owners

- EVERY TEAM HAS AT LEAST TWO OWNERS, and they are both members of organization staff. This is the condition in §3 and it is the one that prevents §8 from being a monthly event.
- The platform does not enforce a minimum owner count. It is enforced by the creation guidance, by the monthly report, and by the annual attestation — so it is a procedure, and procedures need the report behind them to be real.
- The owner's job is small and deliberately so: approve who joins, confirm the membership once a year, say when it is finished, and name a successor before changing role. It is the same job as a site owner's (M365-10 §6), because it is the same object.
- An owner who does not know they are an owner is not one. Whoever creates a Team tells the second owner that they have become one.

7.2 Members

- Members are added by the owners. Membership is not an IT decision and IT does not adjudicate who belongs in a department's Team.
- Where membership should be derived rather than maintained — everyone in a department, every new starter — that is dynamic membership, which is a dynamic group, which needs a directory attribute. Attributes are a finite resource, and a request is often declined because the attribute it needs is already committed to another system. Check the attribute register before promising anything (M365-04 §7).

- Temporary workers are members like anyone else, and their membership ends at the end of the engagement with the rest of their access (ACC-09).

7.3 Guests

Guest participation in a Team is governed by ACC-10 (which identity the person should have, who sponsors it, how it ends) and M365-14 (what they can reach). Neither is restated here. Four things belong in this document because they are Teams-specific:

- A guest is never a Team owner. Ownership is a staff responsibility (ACC-10 §5).
- Adding an external person to a Team creates a tenant guest — a real identity, with a real sign-in and an MFA registration. That is a different act from inviting them to a meeting, and the difference matters. M365-08 §6 covers it from the meeting side.
- Guests appear with their organisation in the display name, so that no member of the Team has to work out whether the person reading the channel is external (ACC-10 §4).
- A shared channel is usually the better instrument for external collaboration than guest membership of the whole Team, because it scopes what the external party sees to the thing you are actually working on together.

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8. Expiry, orphan detection and ownership reassignment

8.1 Expiry

- Group lifetime is set to 365 days. Owners are notified before expiry and renew with one click.
- Auto-renewal on activity is enabled, and it should be understood for what it is: a safety net that stops an active Team disappearing because its owners were on leave. It is NOT a control. A Team that one person opens once a quarter renews itself for ever without anybody deciding it should exist.
- The control is the annual attestation (§8.2), not the expiry. The expiry catches abandonment; the attestation catches the Team that is still there but is no longer for anything.
- An expired group is recoverable for 30 days, then it is not. Nothing in this document relies on that window being noticed.

8.2 The annual owner attestation

Run once a year with the rest of the access recertification cycle (ACC-17). Each owner receives their Teams and answers three questions about each: is this still needed, is this membership still right, and are you still the right owner? Five minutes, from a list IT sends. An owner who does not respond is escalated once and then the Team goes to §8.4 as an orphan — a Team nobody will confirm is needed is functionally the same as a Team with no owner.

8.3 Detecting orphans

Tier 3 produces a monthly report. Four conditions, in descending order of urgency:

Condition	What it means	Action
Zero owners	The Team is orphaned now. Nobody can add a member, approve access or archive it.	Reassign under §8.4 within 5 coverage days.
All owners disabled or departed	Orphaned in substance even though the platform still lists owners.	Reassign under §8.4. This is the failure the ACC-01 §7.2 leaver step is meant to prevent, and the report is how the ones that slipped are caught.
Exactly one owner	Not orphaned. One departure away from it.	Ask the owner to name a second. This row is the pipeline for the two above it, and clearing it is cheaper than clearing them.
A private channel whose owners have left	Orphaned separately from the Team, and invisible to the Team's own owners.	Tier 3 reassigns directly. Do not assume the Team's owners can see or fix this — they cannot.

8.4 Ownership reassignment runbook

1. Establish who the Team belongs to before deciding who owns it. Read the stated purpose in the site register (M365-10 §5), the channel names, and the department of the most active members. Do not start from the org chart.
2. Approach the department head, not the most active member. Ownership is a departmental responsibility being reassigned, and asking the busiest person directly usually gets a yes that is regretted later.
3. Where the department head names an owner: add them and a second owner, tell them both in writing that they are now owners, and send them the M365-10 Appendix B one-pager. Two owners, always. Reassigning to one owner recreates the problem on a delay.
4. Where the department head declines, or nobody can say what the Team is for, that is a useful answer rather than a dead end. Take it to §9 as an archive candidate.
5. Where nobody can be found at all, it goes to Tier 4 as a decision. IT does not become the owner by default — that is precisely how a Team becomes nobody's, and IT cannot answer the questions an owner exists to answer (M365-10 §7).
6. Record the reassignment in the site register: previous owners, new owners, who decided, and the date.
7. Where the orphan was caused by a departure that should have been caught at separation, note it — the count of those over a year is the argument for whatever fix is needed in ACC-01 §7.2, and nobody can make that argument without the count.

9. Archive, and why deleting is almost never the answer

	Archive	Delete
What happens	The Team and its site become read-only. Everything is preserved and remains searchable. It disappears from the active Teams list.	The group, the mailbox, the site and the channel conversations are soft-deleted for 30 days, then permanently removed.

	Archive	Delete
Reversible?	Yes, at any time, by an owner or Tier 2.	For 30 days. After that, no.
Cost of getting it wrong	A read-only Team somebody has to un-archive. Two minutes.	A department discovering in month four that four years of their work is gone. There is no recovering from that, and there is no explaining it either.
When it is right	Almost always. A finished project, a dissolved committee, a Team nobody will attest to.	The Team was created in error, contains nothing, and has never been used. Or Tier 4 has approved a disposition under M365-16 §2.

So: archive is the default and deletion is a Tier 4 decision with a record behind it. Nobody has ever been criticised for archiving something that could have been deleted.

- Archiving does not satisfy a retention obligation and does not replace one. Retention is applied to the site and follows M365-16 §3 whether the Team is active or archived.
- Deleting a Team that is under a retention policy preserves the content in a place nobody can browse. That is not the same as having it, and it should not be mistaken for a soft option.
- Before archiving, tell the members. A Team going read-only without warning generates a ticket within the hour and a certain amount of ill will that a two-line message would have prevented.
- Archived Teams are reviewed with the site register annually. An archive is a resting place, not a disposal, and after the retention floor a genuine disposition decision can be made properly (M365-16 §2).

10. Tenant configuration

Tier 3 owns these. Changes go through M365-21. Recorded here so that the intent sits with the standard rather than in somebody's memory of why a setting is the way it is.

Setting	Intent
Who may create Teams and Microsoft 365 groups	Staff. Not temporary or external accounts — a Team created by somebody on a short engagement is an ungoverned site with an owner who leaves. Their project Teams are requested through the sponsoring department.
Group naming policy	Prefix and blocked-word list per §4, subject to the entitlement check in §3.
Group expiration policy	365 days, auto-renew on activity, owner notifications. Subject to the same entitlement check.
Minimum owners	Two. Not platform-enforced — see §7.1 and the monthly report.
Guest access in Teams	On, governed by ACC-10 and M365-14. Owners add guests; guests are never owners.
Who may create private channels	Team owners only. The default permits members, which produces §5.1 faster than anyone expects.
Shared channels and external participation	Owners only, per M365-14.
Deleted group retention	30 days. Not something §9 relies on.

Setting	Intent
Team discoverability	Public Teams are permitted and encouraged for anything that is not sensitive. Discoverability is how the organization avoids building the same Team twice, and the classification (M365-15) decides what may be public.
Third-party apps in Teams	Reviewed before availability. An app added to a Team gets the Team's content, and app consent is a tenant change (M365-21, M365-19).

11. Service levels

Activity	Commitment (per GOV-06)
"Team, channel, site or chat?"	Answered at Tier 1 from §2, in the conversation. This is the highest-value thing Tier 1 does with this document.
Self-service Team creation	Immediate, by the requester. No IT involvement — that is the point of §3.
A Team for a population that cannot self-serve	P3 — 2 coverage days.
A dynamic-membership Team	Tier 3, against the attribute register. Not promised before M365-04 §7 has been checked.
Rename	P3 — 2 coverage days. The requester is told the site URL does not change (§4).
Ownership reassignment from the orphan report	P3 — 5 coverage days. On a departure, within the ACC-01 §7.2 timeline instead.
Archive on owner request	P3 — 2 coverage days.
Deletion	Tier 4 decision. Never same-day, and never on a verbal request.
Monthly orphan report; annual attestation	On schedule, with ACC-17.

12. Records

Record	Held in	Retention
Team entry in the site register: owners, classification, purpose, dates	Site register (M365-10 §5), Team flagged	Life of the Team + 3 years
Monthly orphan report	IT governance record	3 years
Ownership reassignments: previous, new, decided by, date	Site register + ticket	3 years
Annual attestation returns	IT register (ACC-17)	3 years
Archive and un-archive actions	Ticket	3 years
Deletion approvals	Tier 4 record	Permanent

Record	Held in	Retention
Naming and expiry exceptions	IT register	Life of the exception + 3 years

13. Related documents

ID	Title	Relationship
M365-10	SharePoint Site Request, Provisioning & Ownership	Governs the site every Team creates. §6 resolves the apparent conflict at M365-10 §4 step 1.
M365-11	SharePoint & OneDrive Permission Management	How access to the Team's site is actually granted.
M365-04	Distribution List & Dynamic Group Standard	A Team is a group. §4 and §7.2 are written against M365-04 §4 and §7.
M365-03	Shared Mailbox Standard	What a Team is not — a public address people write to.
M365-08	Teams Meetings, Recording & Guest Participation	Meetings held in these Teams, and where their recordings land.
M365-14	External Sharing & Guest Access Governance	What a guest or a shared channel participant can reach.
ACC-10	Guest & Sponsored External Account Standard	Which identity an external person should have, and who sponsors it.
M365-15	Data Classification & Handling	The classification a Team's site carries.
M365-16	Retention, Legal Hold & eDiscovery	§9 disposition, and the private-channel scoping caution at §5.1.
M365-21	Tenant Configuration Change Control	Changes to §10.
ACC-17	Periodic Access Review & Entitlement Recertification	The annual attestation at §8.2.
ACC-01	Account Lifecycle	§7.2 ownership transfer at departure — the step that prevents most orphans.
GOV-06	Service Commitments, Priority & Escalation	Supplies §11.

Appendix A — For end users: Team, channel, site or chat?

Source text for the knowledge base. Format per GOV-05. Written to be published as it stands.

Start here

Before you create a Team, ask yourself one question: do the people involved already work together somewhere? If they do, what you want is a new channel in that Team, not a new Team. It takes ten seconds, everybody already has access, and you have not created something new for somebody to look after.

When you genuinely do want a new Team

When there is a standing group of people with an ongoing shared purpose — a department, a committee, a project with a defined membership and a defined end. Creating one is quick, and there are just two things we ask of you, both of which take a moment now and save a great deal later.

Name it so we can tell what it is	Dept – Front Office. Cmte – Wellbeing. Proj – Portal Refresh (2027). Please do not name it after yourself or after whoever is currently running it, because those change and the name does not.
Add a second owner	Always two. Not because we do not trust you, but because one owner means that when you are on holiday nobody can add a member, and when you change role the Team quietly belongs to nobody. Tell the person you have made them an owner — they will not otherwise know.

What a Team is not

It is not a way to email a group of people. If all you want is to send mail to a set of people, ask us for a distribution list instead — it is simpler and it does not create a site somebody has to own.

It is not an address the public can write to. If people outside the organization need to reach your department, that is a shared mailbox. Ask us; it costs nothing and takes about a day.

It is not a good home for something that will be finished in three weeks. That is a group chat.

A word about group chats

Group chats are perfect for quick conversations and genuinely bad for anything that matters. Files you share in a chat live in your own OneDrive, which means that when you leave the organization they go with it — and the people in the chat lose them without anybody realising. If the files matter, put them in a Team or a site.

Private channels

A private channel inside a Team is for work that genuinely should not be visible to everyone in that Team — a hiring panel, a budget in preparation. Use them sparingly. If you find you need several, it is usually a sign that you actually want two Teams, and separating them will make things much simpler for everyone.

When a Team is finished

Tell us and we will archive it. Archiving keeps everything, makes it read-only, and takes it off everyone’s list — and we can bring it back at any time if you turn out to need it. We would much rather archive something than delete it, and so would you in about two years.

Once a year we will ask you three questions

For each Team you own: is it still needed, is the membership still right, and are you still the right owner? It takes about five minutes from a list we send you, and it is what stops the organization accumulating hundreds of Teams that nobody can account for. If the honest answer is that you are no longer the right owner, please say so — it is genuinely helpful, and it is not a problem.

Appendix B — Orphaned Team reassignment checklist

One per orphaned Team, from the monthly report. Attached to the ticket. An unticked box is a step not done, not a step judged unnecessary.

✓	Step	Evidence
☐	Orphan condition recorded (zero owners / all owners departed / single owner / private channel)	Monthly report reference
☐	Stated purpose read from the site register; last content change noted	Register entry
☐	Content reviewed only far enough to identify the owning department — not read	Note in ticket
☐	Classification checked; where CONFIDENTIAL or above, Tier 4 informed before proceeding	M365-15 record
☐	Department head approached (not the most active member)	Email in ticket
☐	TWO owners named and added	Team ownership list
☐	Both new owners told in writing that they are now owners	Email in ticket
☐	M365-10 Appendix B owner one-pager sent	Email in ticket
☐	Private channels checked separately for their own orphaned owners	Tier 3 confirmation
☐	Site register updated: previous owners, new owners, decided by, date	Register entry
☐	Where nobody could be found: escalated to Tier 4 as a decision, not defaulted to IT	Tier 4 record
☐	Where the department declined: routed to §9 as an archive candidate	Ticket
☐	Where a departure caused it: noted for the annual count against ACC-01 §7.2	Governance record

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Part of the Known Good SOP Catalog by Kevin Zelman, written for small IT shops, contractors and consultants, career-changers and help desk technicians. Adapt the names, tiers and times to your own shop: the times here are cushion, not a promise.